

Introduction

One of the most deeply rooted insights from the study of international politics and world history is that the rise of new powers has the potential to cause geopolitical earthquakes.¹ Rising great powers pose deep challenges to international order, which can provoke hegemonic wars and dramatic changes in the balance of power and the normative and institutional character of international politics. This notion drove Thucydides' narrative of the Peloponnesian War; it animated E.H. Carr's analysis of the "twenty years' crisis"; it was at the core of Robert Gilpin's understanding of the engine of change in world politics; and it explains current trepidation about the consequences of the rise of China for the future of the American-backed liberal international order.²

Yet this widely held conventional wisdom is puzzling. Over the past two hundred years, every attempt to overthrow the international order has ended with the defeat (and in some cases subjugation) of the challenger. Taking this kind of risk only makes sense for a rising power that is deeply dissatisfied with its stake in the status quo. Uncovering the causes of geopolitical earthquakes thus involves explaining why rising powers occasionally adopt deeply revisionist foreign policy objectives.

Unfortunately, revisionism is a poorly understood concept. It often serves as little more than an ad hoc explanation for otherwise inexplicably aggressive behavior. At the same time, it is a central part of any account of how power transitions work in theory and how the rise of China will play out in practice. The debate over whether China will challenge the

¹ The geopolitical "earthquake" metaphor was popularized by Krasner (1982a) as a way of distinguishing between the realisms of Waltz and Gilpin.

² Thucydides (1972); Carr (1946); Gilpin (1981). For recent work on the rise of China, see Christensen (2015); Pillsbury (2015); Goldstein (2015); Friedberg (2015), (2011); Steinberg and O'Hanlon (2014); Kupchan (2014a); Luttwak (2012); White (2012); Ikenberry (2011); Mearsheimer (2010); Jacques (2009); and Goldstein (2005). Of course, the even greater trepidation (at least at the moment) about the consequences of the Trump administration's approach to foreign policy for the international order serves as an important reminder that the rise of new powers is not the *only* source of geopolitical earthquakes.

US-backed liberal order – whether the rise of China will provoke a geopolitical earthquake – comes down to a disagreement about the causes of revisionism in rising states. That such a critical question hinges on such a murky concept demands renewed attention to the nature and sources of variation in satisfaction with the status quo among rising powers.

This book offers a novel conceptualization of revisionism and a new theoretical explanation for the sort of dissatisfaction that causes geopolitical earthquakes. I disaggregate the concept and distinguish between two dimensions of revisionism. The first – distributive dissatisfaction – describes a desire to acquire *more* of something: more influence, more territory, more wealth, more status. The second – normative dissatisfaction – describes a desire to protest, delegitimize, or overthrow the rules, norms, and institutions of the status quo order. Distributive dissatisfaction can lead to conflict and war, but it does not in itself cause geopolitical earthquakes because it can often be satisfied within the boundaries of the broader order. But when distributive dissatisfaction is combined with normative dissatisfaction, it produces *radical* revisionism. Radical revisionists not only seek to adjust the distribution of benefits and resources in the system, they also positively value taking steps that signal protest against, delegitimize, or aim to overthrow the status quo order's norms, rules, and institutions. This is the kind of revisionism that helped produce the geopolitical earthquakes that were World Wars I and II: foreign policy in Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Nazi Germany combined commitments to adjusting the distribution of resources in their favor with commitments to overthrowing the normative and institutional foundations of the status quo orders within which each rose to power. Radical revisionism made these three rising powers particularly dangerous because it meant that their drives to expand were relatively unconstrained by a countervailing urge to communicate restraint.

Radical revisionism is as puzzling as it is significant. Rising powers have incentives to signal that they plan to abide by the rules, norms, and institutions that constitute the status quo order even as they seek to increase their power, wealth, territory, and status. Doing so allays the fears of other states and reduces the likelihood that the rising power will face a countervailing coalition. Leaders in China have understood this logic since the time of Deng Xiaoping – and leaders in Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and interwar Germany understood it as well. Yet, in the latter three cases, leaders ultimately ignored the logic of institutional restraint and instead took provocative steps that signaled deep dissatisfaction with the foundation of the order. This is the puzzle at the core of this book: why do rising states, which have compelling

reasons to signal restraint, sometimes instead pursue policies that communicate a determination to reject and challenge the status quo order – policies that raise the risk of geopolitical earthquakes?

The Argument in Brief

My argument, like Gilpin's, revolves around the idea that *thwarted ambitions* create forces that push the rising state to grow deeply dissatisfied with the status quo. But while Gilpin and other realists emphasize the material benefits of overthrowing the old order, my argument acknowledges that these are rarely worth the costs and risks, especially for a rising power. A satisfying explanation for the pursuit of policies aimed at overturning – as opposed to reforming or expanding within – the status quo order thus has to go beyond rational calculations of material self-interest.

Instead, I argue that obstructed *status* ambitions unleash social psychological and domestic political forces within rising states that push them to reject and challenge the status quo order. Individuals care about the status of their state for the same reason that they care about the status of their hometown baseball team or their alma mater: social identity and its influence on self-esteem. As states become more powerful, their foreign policies often express not only a desire for more power and wealth, but also – in response to demands from nationalist individuals and groups whose social identities are invested in the state's standing – ambitions for higher status. The drive for international status takes the form of policies aimed at acquiring markers of high status – like advanced technology, military victories, and institutional reforms – along with demands that other states behave in ways that recognize the rising state's new position and the rights and privileges it entails.

Sometimes, established powers seem persistently unwilling to do so, which may convince individuals within the rising state that their status ambitions are incompatible with the international order. This constitutes a condition that I call status immobility – the belief that the state faces a status “glass ceiling” – which has two critical consequences for the rising state's foreign policy. First, it contributes to demands from some individuals and groups that the state pursue policies that reject – as opposed to integrate within or reform – the status quo order. The logics that link the perception of an international status “glass ceiling” to a demand for policies that reject the international order are similar to those that motivate disadvantaged social groups *inside* states to protest or secede when they lack an effective legitimate avenue for redressing grievances. Status immobility prompts demands for rejectionist policies both out of a consequentialist drive to remove the perceived obstacle to the state's

status ambitions and out of a social psychological need to avoid ratifying an unjust order and prevent the state from participating in its own humiliation. Second, prominent discourses and widespread beliefs about the presence of an unjust, insoluble obstacle to status satisfaction produces political resources that advantage hardliners over moderates in domestic contests over the direction of foreign policy.

In sum, status immobility unleashes forces that undermine the ability of rising states to pursue policies aimed at reassuring established powers that their ambitions are limited. It does so by motivating and incentivizing behavior that lashes out in protest against the status quo order, not necessarily because there is anything material to gain by doing so but rather because defying or attempting to overthrow an unjust order seems more attractive than meekly accepting the rising state's place within it.

Status in International Politics

Apart from proposing a new explanation for an important form of revisionism, the book's most significant contribution is to expand our conception of the role that status plays in international politics. There is nothing new about suggesting that status concerns affect the way states interact. This is a claim that goes back to Thucydides, is an important theme in the work of twentieth-century classical realists and early constructivists, and has generated two modern periods of sustained scholarly interest, one that began in the early 1970s and petered out by the end of the next decade, and the current literature that took off just after the turn of the twenty-first century.³

Both of these literatures have focused primarily on how states seek status. This is sensible, and has generated important advances in our knowledge of the way international relations work. For example, scholars have established that states sometimes fight wars in order to achieve higher status, and that they often build weapons not for security reasons but because doing so is a way of performing a claim to membership in a status club.

But status matters in ways that go well beyond its current role as an objective that states pursue strategically. This book suggests two new ways of thinking about status: as the source of a largely non-instrumental demand for revolt against the status quo order, and as a political resource that influences domestic contests over foreign policy.

³ The earlier literature was primarily quantitative and focused on the relationship between status inconsistency and war (Galtung 1964; East 1972; Wallace 1971, 1973; Gochman 1980). The modern literature is more diverse (see Dafoe, Renshon, and Huth 2014; and Larson, Paul, and Wohlforth 2014 for overviews).

Beyond Status-Seeking

The standard model for thinking about the role of status in international politics treats the concept as an objective, and then analyzes the ways in which states pursue it. The focus is usually on establishing that some state took some action not because it wanted more power or more security, but rather because it wanted more status. Scholars have adopted a variety of empirical strategies for defending this claim, and they have done so persuasively across a number of different substantive contexts: wars, arms races, participation in humanitarian missions, and domestic institutional reforms have all been successfully attributed to the ambition for higher status.

This book casts status in a new light. Its role as an objective remains important, but my focus is on how obstructed status ambitions can prompt responses that are not aimed at seeking status but at managing the social psychological and political consequences of being unable to do so. Status immobility produces demands for policies that reject the status quo order not just because this may seem like the only way of satisfying the ambition, but also because defying and delegitimizing the order avoids the indignity of being complicit in one's own humiliation. In Chapters 4 and 5, for instance, I analyze the Japanese and German decisions to withdraw from the League of Nations in 1933. Status concerns are implicated in both decisions. Yet it is difficult to see how withdrawal could have helped either state achieve higher status, and this is not how Japanese or German leaders understood it. Instead, withdrawal represented a *protest* against an order that was seen as unjust because it seemed to be incompatible with Japanese and German status ambitions.

This is a critical point because of its relationship to questions about the persistence of international order. Status-seeking often requires that states behave in ways that ratify and reproduce the institutions and norms that constitute the status quo order. This is just as true of peaceful emulation – like Meiji Japan's effort to boost its standing in the world by becoming civilizational Western – as it is of more conflictual emulation – like Wilhelmine Germany's construction of a fleet of battleships. In either case, the state seeking higher status does things that acknowledge the value of characteristics that the established power has in abundance – this is, after all, partly why these characteristics are status symbols in the first place. What this means is that while status-seeking may cause the international hierarchy to adjust, it also reinforces the deeper normative foundations of international order. Japan's attempt to become institutionally Western reinforced notions about the superiority of Western norms and institutions just as Germany's attempt to equal the British battle fleet

reinforced notions about the importance of seapower in world politics. According to the standard model, in other words, status ambitions act as a centripetal force, pulling the international order together even as states compete for position.⁴

In this book, I offer an account of one way in which status ambitions can contribute to the *destruction* of international order. Status ambitions that seem incompatible with the status quo order may not incentivize status-seeking but push toward policies that protest, delegitimize, or aim to overthrow – and thereby weaken rather than strengthen – the foundations of order.

Status and the Second Image Reversed

The theory I develop in this book recasts status in a second novel role: as an international political force that influences domestic contests over the direction of foreign policy. In other words, I build a second-image reversed theory that links status dynamics with the politics of foreign policy in rising states. Unlike other accounts that posit status as an interest that unitary actors pursue strategically, I argue that status concerns often influence policy through pressure on leaders from those outside the regime, and that status immobility serves as a potent weapon for hardliners to deploy against moderates. And because status immobility is partially generated by the behavior of foreign actors, this constitutes one channel through which international political processes influence domestic political processes.⁵

This innovation complicates matters, but it promises significant benefits, one of which is methodological. Theories about how status influences international politics often lack convincing, testable mechanisms, in part because they import insights from fields meant to explain the behavior of individuals – like social psychology – without taking seriously the complications this involves. And the absence of convincing, testable mechanisms means that persuasive qualitative analysis is difficult. This leaves the field to quantitative and experimental analysis, both of which are valuable but inadequate. Quantitative tests of hypotheses about status and international politics are limited because they rely on a particularly problematic measure of status, which is calculated using data on diplomatic exchange. Experimental analysis is useful for testing hypotheses about individual attitudes and decisionmaking, but it can only tell us so much

⁴ Lebow (2008), p. 67; and Suzuki (2008), p. 60.

⁵ On the “second-image reversed,” see Gourevitch (1978). For similar arguments, see Evangelista (1993) and Snyder (1989).

about the ways in which status actually matters in international politics. These approaches must be supplemented by rigorous qualitative work, but rigorous qualitative work cannot advance unless theorists more carefully specify the processes through which status influences foreign policy and international politics.⁶ This book is, in part, an attempt to address the paucity of convincing mechanisms in analyses of status in world politics by explicitly bringing domestic politics back in.

Outline of the Book

The remainder of the book develops and evaluates the argument using evidence from the most important power transitions in modern history. In Chapter 1, I develop a new conception of revisionism. International orders consist of both a distribution of resources and a set of norms, rules, and institutions that constitute actors, allow them to legitimate action, and regulate state behavior. Rising powers can be satisfied or dissatisfied with the state of either, both, or neither of these dimensions. Chapter 1 explains why policies that simultaneously express dissatisfaction at both the distributive and normative levels – which I call radical revisionism – are dangerous and puzzling. The chapter argues that three existing explanations for shifts toward radical revisionism – based on the costs and benefits of overthrowing the order, the distance between the normative and institutional characteristics of the rising state and the status quo order, and the dynamics of domestic political entrapment – are valuable but inadequate.

Chapter 2 develops the theoretical argument. I begin by defining status and introducing the concept of status immobility. I then lay out the logic linking status immobility to preferences for policies that protest, delegitimize, or overthrow the norms, rules, and institutions of the status quo order; and explain why prominent discourses of and widespread beliefs about status immobility strengthens hardliners at the expense of moderates. The chapter concludes by discussing my strategy for evaluating the theory's ability to explain shifts toward radical revisionism in rising powers.

⁶ For quantitative work, see fn. 3 and more recently Rhamey and Early (2013); Renshon (2016, 2017); Bezerra et al. (2015); and Miller et al. (2015); for experimental work, see Renshon (2015, 2017). There has been much valuable qualitative work on status published over the past decade (for instance, Wohlforth 2009; Larson and Shevchenko 2010; and Lebow 2008), but it has been less interested in elaborating causal mechanisms than in establishing that states care about status and theorizing about how the status motive might lead to outcomes different than those expected by approaches focused on material motives.

Chapters 3, 4, and 5 constitute the core empirical assessment of status immobility theory. These chapters focus on critical junctures in the histories of three of the twentieth century's most striking revisionist rising powers: Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar/Nazi Germany. For each case, I identify and analyze a shift away from distributive revisionism toward radical revisionism and show that it cannot be understood without taking into account the dynamics that status immobility theory highlights. Chapter 3 examines the origins of Germany's determination to challenge the European balance of power in the years after 1911. I argue that it is impossible to fully understand why many Germans wanted to overthrow the European status quo order without considering the effects of the belief that Germany's ambition to be recognized as a "world power" was incompatible with the institution of the balance of power and especially with Great Britain's role in maintaining it. Moreover, accumulating evidence that the British were unwilling to recognize Germany's claim to *Weltpolitik* – evidence that came in the form of the Morocco Crises and London's response to Germany's naval policy – appears to have substantially weakened the moderate Chancellor Theobald von Bethmann Hollweg's position vis-à-vis German hardliners in the years before the July Crisis.

Chapter 4 investigates the origins of Imperial Japan's turn against the interwar Washington Conference system during the early 1930s. I show that Japan's most visible protest against the interwar order – its 1933 withdrawal from the League of Nations – was the result of outrage against what the Japanese understood to be the West's unwillingness to treat Japan as a full-fledged great power. Japan's withdrawal from the League seems trivial today, but it helped to strengthen Japanese hardliners at the expense of moderates in subsequent fights over other elements of the interwar order.

The shift from Gustav Stresemann's moderate, pragmatic foreign policy to the stridently rejectionist approaches of the late Weimar Republic and Germany under Hitler is the focus of Chapter 5. I show that German radical nationalists demanded, throughout the 1920s, the wholesale rejection of the Versailles settlement and the broader interwar order for reasons linked to status immobility. Stresemann's inability to lift the humiliating sanctions quickly enough through participation in the institutions of the interwar order was interpreted as evidence that Germany faced a status "glass ceiling," which by the end of the decade contributed to political conditions favorable to radical nationalist proponents of rejecting the order. This played a critical role in the rise to power of a leader – Adolf Hitler – who was deeply committed to a radical revisionist foreign policy.

Chapter 6 analyzes the Anglo-American power transition. This is a negative case – one in which a rising great power did not pursue policies aimed at protesting, delegitimizing, or overthrowing the order within which it rose. The chapter has two purposes. The first is to explore the sources of British accommodation, and in particular to ask how the British managed the status anxiety associated with being overtaken by the rising United States. The second purpose is to strengthen the case that status immobility matters by using counterfactual methods to establish that it could have exercised a concrete influence on American foreign policy. I accomplish this task by imagining how history might have been different if the British had not accommodated American status claims during the 1895–1896 Venezuela Crisis.

Chapter 7 establishes the importance of status immobility for understanding the consequences of the ongoing rise of China. Will the rise of China bring on the end of the liberal international order? I argue that this depends in part on whether its status claims are accommodated. China has important outstanding status ambitions, which involve – most significantly – the claim to a sphere of influence in East Asia. There are surely also economic and security motives for Beijing's drive to expand its influence in the South China Sea, but status dynamics are implicated because Chinese leaders seem to understand a sphere of influence in their near abroad as one of the rights of a great power. What this means is that accommodating Chinese status claims would likely have to involve a dramatic reduction in the American role as a provider of security and order in East Asia. This would be costly (perhaps prohibitively so), but failing to accommodate would come with its own set of costs – the activation of social psychological and domestic political forces that could advantage Chinese proponents of rejecting the set of liberal norms, rules, and institutions that constitute today's status quo order.

In the conclusion, I summarize the empirical value added by recognizing the role of status immobility in the process of rising power foreign policy change and highlight directions for future research raised by the theory's limitations. The book ends by considering my argument's implications for American grand strategy as it faces a series of rising and reemerging great powers.